struggle against modern revisionism to the end'.[42] The victory over India in the 1962 War had shown that China possessed enough military muscle to inflict a crushing defeat on another major Asian power. It had also, as intended, deprived India of its role as a major voice for the newly independent countries in Asia and Africa.

It was time for Mao and his trusted lieutenants, among them his wife Jiang Qing, Defence Minister Lin Biao, and the spymaster Kang Sheng to begin to purge the Party—and to assert China's role as the leader of not only the international Communist movement but also the entire Third World. But first, China needed a nuclear bomb.

China's interest in nuclear weapons began during the Korean War, when they learned that the United States was contemplating the use of atomic bombs to halt the advance of Chinese so-called volunteers, who came streaming down the peninsula in human waves. China had already in the early 1950s developed its own production of small arms, rockets, and artillery with technology imported from the Soviet Union and with the help of Soviet technicians. Then, in January 1955, Mao called a meeting of the Central Committee of the CCP to discuss starting a nuclear weapons programme. The following year, PLA Marshal Nie Rongzhen worked with the Chinese Academy of Sciences to establish a Nuclear Research Institute at an undisclosed location and the programme began to acquire content and direction.[43] Between 1955 and 1958, the Soviet Union and China signed six accords related to the development of nuclear science, industry, and weapons.[44]

In 1957, Marshal Nie Rongzhen travelled to Moscow to sign one of those treaties by which the Soviet Union pledged to provide aid in nuclear research, missile development, and aviation technology. That pledge included a prototype atomic bomb and related missile technology.[45] But a split between the Soviet Union and China was already developing, although it would not become public until 1961. Nie, however, was convinced that China would be able to progress with its nuclear programme even without Soviet assistance.

In 1958–60, when millions of people were starving to death throughout China, another high-ranking PLA officer, Chen Shiqu, moved 40,000 special engineering troops to Lop Nur, a former salt lake in the deserts of Xinjiang, to commence the construction of a nuclear testing site. Then, on